

Staff Commendations

April 2026

I want to recognize Michelle Benning. I am the Study Hall Monitor at Oak View and Michelle plays such a vital role for me. I am not able to access and print the missing assignments reports and she gets it done on a weekly basis for me. She also prints rosters when I need them. Everytime I come to Michelle with an issue or needing assistance she is always willing to help.
-Lindsey Eckart

We would like to celebrate North Ridge Elementary Principal April Heitland (with our parent hat on). No matter the weather conditions, April is always out helping with arrival and dismissal. It's clear she understands the enhanced challenges that come with this 15-20 minute time period, and she is ready to help! She calls each student by name and has memorized a lot of the cars that are coming in and out of North Ridge. Thanks for leading the way for student safety! We appreciate you.
-AJ and Tara Ellingson

Jolie Morgan and Lindsay Kasperbauer- their organization and patience during ISASP testing at the high school helped the process move smoothly.
-Lisa Battistone

Thank you to the wonderful Prom 2026 chaperones: Katy Forsythe, Will Janssen, Nathan Gross, Bob Geurink, Dustin Grothoff, April Busch, Scott Heitland, Jonny Getting, Grant Bohlke, Deb Foss, Kayla Holland, and Sandi Ellis. I also want to thank Officers Loutzenhiser and Spracklen, Sheila Hudson, Austin Roy, and Matthew Blackmore. You all helped to make the evening memorable, fun, and safe for our students.
-Danell Duncan

Emma Hartman: Emma Hartman is one of the happiest and uplifting teachers I know. She constantly goes above and beyond and differentiates as much as she can to help her students grow. Emma is passionate about advocating for all of the students who need it. Her enthusiasm, compassion, and dedication create a welcoming and inclusive classroom environment where students feel encouraged, valued, and motivated to do their best.
-Chloe Nixon

Sam Stumberg: Sam Stumberg does a great job creating strong and positive relationships with his students. If you walked in his classroom, you would notice that he created an environment where students feel valued and confident in expressing themselves. Sam consistently goes above and beyond to engage his students, making learning meaningful and accessible for everyone.

-Chloe Nixon

To Renae Conway and Leah Mertz:

Thank you for the time, energy, and expertise you dedicated to preparing and presenting professional development for our staff. Your thoughtful planning, passion, and insights into both extending and supporting student learning provided valuable strategies that teachers can immediately apply in their classrooms. We are incredibly grateful for your leadership and willingness to share your knowledge. Thank you for supporting the growth of all staff and students.

-Abby Crannell and Heidi Kuberski

Shoutout to our amazing Middle School Green Pod team—Kim Flynn, Trish Gurnsey, Jacob Heinemann, and Michaela Peters—for celebrating the great days and being there for each other on the hard ones! Your collaboration and willingness to support one another makes such a positive impact. So grateful for all of you!

-Barbara Kellner

I would like to recognize Michelle Benning and Jim Shutt for their tremendous work and help with ISASP this year! We had a smooth week of testing, which is largely in part to Michelle prepping envelopes and Jim arriving early to the building to set things up. Literal Dream Team!

-Emily Waugh

I would like to recognize Kensila Manley for the excellent work she has done in her first year of teaching preschool in the DC-G school district. It is very challenging to move to a new city and start a new job in a new school district, but Ms. Kensi has done it amazingly well. She is so good with the kids, keeping a balance between fun and discipline. But the thing I appreciate the most is her openness to us, her associates. She always listens to my ideas and suggestions without feeling threatened. She has developed good relationships with the preschool team and fits right in! I am so grateful you have joined our team, Kensi!

-Valarie Rich

I'd like to recognize Kim Brauckman, an associate at Oak View. She takes the time to understand the kid's needs and to dive even deeper to see how she can help. She's equally helpful to her co-workers and never hesitates to give sound advice.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Myriah Burdit, a SPED teacher at Oak View. She must have come into this job with an extra set of hands because it would be impossible to juggle as much as she does otherwise. And through it all she extends so much care and kindness to the kids and those she works with, it's humbling. She obviously has some extra heart to go with those extra hands.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Jeff Cain, a SPED teacher at Oak View. I don't think there's ever been a time when one of his students has seen him and their face didn't light up. Even during the busiest times he'll stop just to make someone smile and brighten their day.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Kendra Foster, an associate at Oak View. She is so unassuming in her daily work, but deserves to be praised for the care she gives to each student. She finds novel ways to bring out their best and keep them engaged. She fills the days with fun and her lightheartedness.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Sheri Fuller, a teacher and associate at Oak View. I admire the way she tries new activities to draw her students into learning. She's dedicated, caring and truly available for her kids. She will always hear them out to better understand them and their needs.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Andrea Hankins, an associate at Oak View. She is an amazing, humble hard worker. Stepping up time and time again wherever there is a need. She keeps things running smoothly with a loving spirit that is always putting the students need's first. She finds new ways to challenge all our learners.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Bethany Johnson, an associate at Oak View. It is so inspiring how she always finds a way to meet students where they are. She is an innovator, constantly coming up with new ideas and tools to make sure each child is included and challenged.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Kirsten Lundy, an associate at Oak View. Selfless is a perfect word to describe Kirsten. She doesn't hesitate to step in and make sure the child she is with is put first. Quietly and with no fanfare, she will go out of her way to bring joy to the kids with projects she takes on herself.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Cindy Nelson, an associate at Oak View. Sometimes things can get a little chaotic, and when they do you'll find Cindy lending a helping hand with a steady calmness. She is such a welcoming person and makes days better with her homemade treats and kind smile.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Sarah Pylikki, an associate at Oak View. This lady is unstoppable-and thank goodness she is! With her heart of gold, she's spent her own money to make sure a child was fed something that worked for them. She doesn't let anything limit her when it comes to making sure each child has a path they can travel and grow on.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Meagan Waterman, an associate at Oak View. She may be the brightest spirit at Oak View! She truly connects to each child and puts her heart into making sure they feel cared for. I see her devoting her time coaching, sacrificing to make sure her kids know she's in their corner. She will come running for a student in need and be able to use the relationships she's built to see them through.

-Kassie Jordan

I'd like to recognize Rodney Whitney, an associate at Oak View. He is so upbeat, funny and full of energy. That enthusiasm gets passed onto his students. He is also dedicated. I've watched him grab a few supplies to quickly demonstrate an eclipse for science or step in with his own cleaning machine to wash a stain so a child's favorite chair can be used again quickly.

-Kassie Jordan

Bethany Johnson, Meagan Waterman, Rod Whitney, Jeff Cain, Myriah Burditt, and Dulcenea Clarke - Thank you for going above and beyond to ensure everything ran smoothly for our student while I was gone on maternity leave. It was such a relief to be able to focus on my family and know things were taken care of! I truly appreciate the collaboration you had with my long term sub and all of the extra work you each put in!

-Anna Anderson

A huge thank you goes out to Klaire Jungling, Megan Klein, Shea Jorgensen, Nicole Landwehr, Asia Olson, and Austin Rix for opening up your classrooms and welcoming a group of visiting teachers to see your amazing MyView Literacy lessons in action! We were all impressed to see the way you engaged the students in their learning, and you are implementing MyView in creative ways! The students were achieving at high levels, and that was exciting to see! Your vulnerability, courage, and flexibility is much appreciated!! Thank you!

-Tyra Behnkendorf

Aliyah Friesner and Maddie Stites: Thanks for all that you do for our new student. I can see so much growth in the short time she has been with DCG.....thanks to your efforts!

-Jenny Rants

A huge shout out to Flora Khosravi! I appreciate her willingness to jump in wherever she is needed and always with a smile on her face. I could not do my job without her!

-Jenny Rants

I would like to recognize and thank Megan Kline for her constant support, collaboration and positivity. Megan is consistently thoughtful towards each of her student's academic and social/emotional needs. Her knowledge and creativity is impressive and appreciated. I feel extremely fortunate to work with such a talented and caring educator. I'm looking forward to continuing our teamwork into next year. Thank you for your leadership!

-Shea Jorgensen

*I would like to commend **Dr. Greg Carenza** for his hard work, organization, and clear communication in making ISASP testing month a success. His expertise in School Improvement is greatly appreciated and plays an important role in moving our district forward, benefiting all students and staff.*

-Deb Cale

*I would like to thank **Steph Madsen** for being the heart of our building and for the way she warmly welcomes everyone who walks through our doors. Her smile and joyful laughter truly brighten the day for all of us at DCE, and her positive presence makes a meaningful difference in our school community.*

-Deb Cale

I would like to celebrate Diann Williamson, Patty Morris, and April Heitland. I am truly grateful for their collaboration, support, and kindness over the past nine years. They have made my experience at DCG both meaningful and memorable. Their dedication and positivity have made them exceptional colleagues, and they will always hold a special place in my heart.

-Deb Cale

I would like to recognize our TK/K (Gena Pierce, Sarah Irlmeier, Michelle Mickle, and Stacie Walker) team for their thoughtful planning and preparation for Countdown to Kindergarten Night, ensuring a welcoming and informative experience for our incoming families. Their collaboration and attention to detail reflect our commitment to setting students up for a successful start to their educational journey.

-April Heitland

Deanna Weber, Sherie Ewers, Mary Deahr, Lori Wyld, Delilah Bonner, and Jeanette Bodermann played an essential role in the success of Countdown to Kindergarten Night, providing a warm, welcoming environment for our incoming students and families. Their flexibility, teamwork, and commitment to supporting both staff and students exemplify the positive culture we strive to create across our schools.

-April Heitland

Erin Bryant's behind-the-scenes efforts and clear, consistent communication were instrumental in making Countdown to Kindergarten Night a success. Her positive attitude and welcoming presence helped create an organized, supportive experience for both families and staff.

-April Heitland

Thank you to Greg Carenza for his leadership, hard work, and clear communication in coordinating ISASP testing across the district. His organization and attention to detail ensured a smooth and successful testing experience for both students and staff.

-April Heitland

Thank you to Ashton Reames for her dedicated support during ISASP testing. Her flexibility and willingness to step in wherever needed helped ensure a smooth and positive experience for students and staff.

-April Heitland

Thank you to Heidi Kuberski, Rebecca Skow, Madison Grove, Brandon Fitch, and Molly Reed, our School Improvement Leadership Team. They are commended for their thoughtful work with SAMI and their continued leadership in goal setting to drive student achievement. Their commitment to reflection, collaboration, and continuous improvement is instrumental in moving our district forward.

-April Heitland